

Sentinels of the Dawn

Poor Clares Perpetual Adoration
Our Lady of the Angels Monastery
Troyes, France

Easter 2014 Issue 16

The empty tomb – a sign of new life!

Now on the first day of the week, Mary Magdalene came early to the tomb, while it was still dark, and she saw the stone taken away from the tomb… Jn 20:1

In his Sunday catechism class several weeks before Easter, Phillip's teacher introduced a special project. She gave every member a plastic egg. She explained that each child was to go outside, find a symbol for new life and put it into the egg. Enthusiastically, the children responded.

Some time later, the children gathered back in the classroom. The eggs were opened one at a time and each child explained the meaning of his symbol. In the first egg was a pretty flower; in the next a beautiful butterfly, while green grass was in a third. The children marveled at the each visible sign of "new life". In another was a rock, which prompted loud laughter.



Finally the last egg was opened – but there was nothing inside! The children grumbled, saying, "Someone didn't do it right!" The teacher felt a tug on her shirt. It was Phillip, who said, "That's mine, and I did do it right! It's empty, because Jesus' tomb was empty." Remember the assignment? Find a symbol for new life. There was an unusual, thoughtful silence. And strangely, from that time on, Phillip was accepted as part of the group.

You see, Phillip was born handicapped, and throughout his childhood, he struggled with many physical problems. That summer he picked up an infection that most children would easily have shaken off. But Philip's weak body couldn't and a few weeks later, he died.

At his funeral Phillip's teacher and his classmates brought their symbol of remembrance and placed it near his coffin. Their unusual gift of love to Phillip wasn't flowers. It was an empty egg – now a symbol to them of new life and hope. It was Phillip who had helped his friends see the wonderful hope in the message of Easter.

An empty tomb: this is indeed the great message of Easter! The resurrection of Jesus from the dead is at the very center of what we believe. The empty tomb speaks our faith – it speaks of a God who can conquer all things, who can triumph over all things, who can transform and change any situation into one that burst with life – not even death has power over this God of ours!

And how much we need to be mindful of this message more than ever before. In the midst of all of the trial and violence and strife and war in our world, God tells us that He will raise us to new life, new possibilities, new ways to care for one another, to love one another, to establish peace. God will renew us, transform us, change us, make us new, bring us to new life! The empty tomb has become the womb of new life! The joy of Easter is not only that God has raised Christ from the dead. Easter joy is also about the possibility and the promise that, regardless of what our lives are like now, new life is available to each one of us here and now. The end of the resurrection story is the beginning of our life. Christ is Risen! We are called to give witness to this Good News and to live it fully. *Alleluia! Alleluia!*



May the peace, joy and love of the Risen Christ fill your heart throughout the Eastertide.
You and your intentions are remembered in our prayers before the Most Blessed Sacrament.
We wish you and your loved ones a Blesed Easter!

Life in a beehive





Since the beginning of 2014 life in the Monastery has been anything but dull! The image of a beehive comes to mind when we think about the activity and events of each passing day. We would like to share with you some of our projects, those that have been completed and those that continue to unfold. But most importantly, we invite you to join us a hymn of thanksgiving to God for the wonders of His love and mercy in our daily life…which are as sweet as honey!

As promised in our last newsletter we would like to share with you another project that began last year and was completed at the beginning of 2014. Thanks to a generous donation from an Association that wishes to remain anonymous, we received the means to remodel two rooms that now serve as a sewing workshop for our Sisters. New windows, heating and additional lighting were installed and the original oak floors were sanded and sealed. A dear friend and benefactor put the final touches on the project by paying the expenses to have the rooms painted. The bright yellow walls are a reminder of her cheerful, giving spirit. An association in Paris also provided us with some needed equipment. A special thank you to our faithful architect, Mr. Jacques Téqui, for once again overseeing this project with much zeal and energy. Once the work was finished, the Sisters had the big task of transferring all the supplies, organizing the space and getting the sewing machines running again! Within a short amount of time our Sister Seamstress was back to work, with the assistance of two of our Sisters on various sewing projects for Artisanat Monastique and alb orders. May they "sew and reap" a hundredfold!









Every spring our cloistered garden is a marvel to behold! Our eyes take in the beauty of God's creation as a variety of colorful tulips open up to the rays of Brother Sun, our ears hear the harmonious melody of birds singing at the break of dawn. This spring, we have a few additions in our garden! Our eyes are beholding scaffolding and our ears the sounds of workers repairing our roof! Phase two of our project began in mid-April and we are happy to see the progress that is being made in such a short amount of time. We are very grateful to all our benefactors whose financial support and prayers have made it possible for us to continue this endeavor, which is scheduled for completion by the end of summer. May God bless you!





We are very grateful to some dear friends of and benefactors of our Monastery who came to our rescue this spring.



Thanks to their generosity, our garden was tilled and they provided us with seeds and plants for the season.



Opening the doors of our hearts to the youth



La Nuit des Monastères (Night of Monasteries) is a yearly event that takes place in our diocese of Troyes. Its goal is to encourage people, especially the youth, to discover the beauty of Religious Life, to encounter the priests, monks, active and contemplative religious of the diocese and come to know and understand their particular charism. This year the Marianist Brothers and our Community were asked to "open our doors" to a group of youth who are preparing for the Sacrament of Confirmation.

On the evening of March 15th, several youth, accompanied by priests, religious and other chaperons arrived at our Monastery. Joining them after their "picnic" in our Parlor, each of the Sisters had the opportunity to present herself and share a little about her vocation. Afterwards, a Sister gave a beutiful witness of our life as Adorers of the Most Blessed Sacrament. A slideshow prepared by another Sister gave the youth the opportunity to see a few glimpses of our "hidden life" in the cloister. Our Sister Violinist lifted their spirits as she played Vivaldi's "Spring" from *The Four Seasons.* Finally we took some time for questions and answers, some of which proved to be very inquisitive! At the close of the evening, the youth were invited to the Chapel for a quiet time of Adoration before the Blessed Sacrament and to sing Compline with the Sisters. It was an enjoyable evening for one and all, and we were particularly impressed with their joyful and energetic spirit, as well as their interest in our way of life.

The following is a short excerpt of a witness that two of the youth, Gautier and Tibaut, wrote about their experience for *La Nuit des Monastères* which we would like to share with you…. *During the event " Night of Monasteries," we discovered that the Poor Clares lived less isolated than we thought. They shared with us a little about their life in the Monastery, one filled with joy…Their common language is French and despite their accent which was sometimes a little difficult to understand, they were able to speak with a smile. We enjoyed when Sister played the violin. She told us that she was a professionaliste before joining the Poor Clares. We thought it was great that she could still continue to play. The prayer vigil in the Chapel was nice; it allowed us to pray in a recollected atmosphere and we were able to place a candle at the foot of the altar. We felt welcomed and it was a great time spent with other young people.*

Please join us in praying for these young men and women that the Lord may guide them in their personal journey of faith, that they may be enlightened by the Holy Spirit as they discern their own vocation.

Celebrating 60 years of the Priesthood :

By Mgr Bernard Savourat,
Chaplain of the Poor Clares of Troyes

In celebrating this jubilee, I thank the Lord for this time given to the service of the Church through the proclamation of the Gospel.

I still remember the day when I left my family and my village at the age of 12 to enter the Minor Seminary of Troyes after I expressed my desire to be a priest.

I give thanks for my parents and my family members whose Christian faith was a support during the twelve years of formation which led me to my priestly ordination.



I give thanks for the ministries which were confided to me by four bishops to serve children, youth, adults as well as the sick.

I give thanks for the youth and adults who grew in their faith and who accepted to take on certain responsabilites in the life of the world and the Church.

I cannot forget to give thanks as well for the special groups of Catholic Action, the parents of children who were concerned about their Catholic education, and for whom I consecrated time for their commitment and formation.



I am deeply grateful for His Excellency André Fauchet from whom I received so much when he called me to work with him in the service of the diocese.

I give thanks for the Community of the Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration. They have reminded me of my days at the seminary when I belonged to a Confraternity of the Blessed Sacrament which gathered together every Sunday after the celebration of Vespers.



It is because of all of this that I believe it is He who leads us along the path of life...

We wish to express our deep gratitude to our Chaplain for his generosity and goodness to our Community. Since our arrival in 2007, he has cared for all of our spiritual needs. We join him in giving thanks to God for all the wonders of these past 60 years and for his faithful service in our diocese. Ad multos annos, Monseigneur!

Special prayer request

On April 5th, two Italian priests and a Candian Sister from the Congregation of Our Lady of Montreal were kidnapped in Cameroun (Africa).



Photo: lapresse.ca

Four years ago, Sister Gilberte Bussière, CND, had come to Troyes, which is the birthplace of their foundress, Saint Margarurite Bourgeys, to celebrate her jubilee. We recommend these three religious to your prayers, that they may soon be released.

FYI

Our new website is up and running!
We invite you to visit us at: www.clarissesdetroyes.com

Please note that the address of our website has changed! It may not look like it has, but if you take a second look, you will notice that our address no longer ends in "org" but "com"!

If you would like to receive our newsletter in PDF format by e-mail, or if you would like to be taken off of our mailing list, please don't hesitate to send us your address.
Contact us at: secretariat.clarissesdetroyes@gmail.com

Monastere des Clarisses
26 Rue Mitantier
10000 Troyes, France



Christ is Risen! Alleluia !

Fundraising with flowers

On April 10th, our Parlor was temporarily transformed into a mini-nursery as members of our Association lined the tables with flowering plants destined for what is becoming our annual garden sale for the benefit of our Monastery. Two of our dear friends, the same who organized our last sale at Christmas, once again offered their talents and time for this event. The sale appears to have been a success, as only a few potted plants remained at the end of the second day. We wish to express our deep appreciation to these two ladies for all of their hard work and their continual interest in helping us obtain funds for our renovation projects, as well as for all those who attended the event. We wish one and all "Happy planting!"



